

The Baroque period

The Baroque period saw the birth of opera, the development of the orchestra, the rise of the keyboard, and the establishment of key structures. Counterpoint was the predominant texture, and musical structures were based on contrast.

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Birth of opera

Intellectuals in Florence, Italy, around 1600 sought new ways of dramatizing stories from ancient Greek and Roman times. Thus, opera was born—a series of songs (arias), sung or spoken narrative (recitative), instrumental items, and choruses, all linked to form a musical drama. In the 1600s and 1700s opera spread and flourished. Operatic works by George Frideric Handel were particularly popular.

Theorbo body



▷ Theorbo

This large lute has “sympathetic” strings, which resonate when others are plucked, the theorbo played “continuo” in recitative, giving a strong bass line and harmonies.

“I should be **sorry** if I only **entertained them**, I wish to **make them better**.”

George Frideric Handel

REAL WORLD

Opera scores

It was customary for the covers and title pages of opera scores, programs, and posters advertising performances to be highly decorative—almost works of art in their own right. Usually engraved, they conveyed an aspect of the story, or hinted at the particular production that awaited the eager audience. They were an important tool for promoting both the work and the profile of the composer.



Rise of instrumental music

“Concerto grosso” (large concert) was one of the favorite forms for string ensembles. It had three movements in which a small group of soloists (concertino) was contrasted with full orchestra (tutti or ripieno), in the “concertante” style.

First movement

Quick

Second movement

Slow and lyrical

Third movement

Lively and cheerful

△ Concerto movements

The first and second movements were often followed by a lively finale, with plenty of repeats of the main tune (ritornelli).

Keyboards to the fore

During the Baroque period, keyboard instruments—mainly harpsichord and clavichord—started to be adopted as solo instruments for the home. Many collections of keyboard music were produced, including Bach’s famous two-volume *The Well-Tempered Clavier* (48 Preludes and Fugues).

▷ Harpsichord

A Baroque harpsichord had one or more manuals (keyboards), and pedals that varied the strings’ sound when pressed down.

